

Chapter 8 - Protection

As if possessed by some demon, Ning Fuyi reached out again toward Chu Qingqiu's throat, a flame-like tongue of fire leaping from her heart and burning through her lungs.

She had never seen Chu Qingqiu's unguarded, soft side - not when she was high and mighty, nor when she was vulnerable. Even when she had imprisoned her in the demon cave years ago, Chu Qingqiu had remained unyielding like an immortal, hatefully so.

Ning Fuyi's gaze grew increasingly dark, like an unfathomably deep ink pool. Her fingertips touched Chu Qingqiu's neck, and her fingers slowly came together.

Chu Qingqiu's expression grew more pained. She suddenly trembled, unconsciously raising her hand to rest it on Ning Fuyi's arm.

That face, which could hold its own against any beauty in the six realms, tilted back slightly, as if trying to avoid Ning Fuyi's fingertips.

A thunderclap exploded in Ning Fuyi's mind, and it felt like cold water had been poured over her entire body. She seemed to awaken from a dream, letting out a long breath while feeling the sticky sweat on her back.

She hastily withdrew her fingers as if that skin had burned her.

Ning Fuyi, oh Ning Fuyi, have you gone mad? You are not the demon king from that demon cave now, but Ning Changfeng's daughter, a disciple of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate! she chided herself harshly, then wiped the sweat from her forehead.

Setting aside whether the marriage contract would work, just the fact that she had harmed Chu Qingqiu would be enough for the entire cultivation world to hunt her to the ends of the earth.

Ning Fuyi shook her head to regain her usual composure, then tentatively placed her hand on Chu Qingqiu's forehead, channeling her immortal power to examine what was happening inside her body.

She wanted to know what was wrong with Chu Qingqiu.

Perhaps due to the marriage contract, this body completely accepted her. Her immortal power could flow through without any obstruction. However, the deeper she went, the more her brows furrowed.

Chu Qingqiu seemed to have suffered very serious injuries. Though nothing showed on the surface, once she investigated internally, she discovered that almost none of her meridians were intact. Her immortal power was no longer as vast as before - it was as if there was a whirlpool inside her body constantly devouring her.

Ning Fuyi withdrew her hand and stared at Chu Qingqiu's bloodless face in shock, momentarily speechless.

With Chu Qingqiu's current cultivation level, who could have tormented her to this extent?

Had it been like this in her previous life too, and she just hadn't known? Or was this some accident in this lifetime?

Ning Fuyi couldn't figure out the reason, and with Chu Qingqiu unconscious, she could only set aside her doubts for now. She placed Chu Qingqiu back in her original position and stood up herself. Fortunately, her injuries weren't fatal - she had only fallen unconscious temporarily due to forcibly circulating her power, which had caused her immortal meridians to become even more damaged.

Chu Qingqiu's hall had always been sparsely furnished, containing only a cold stone bed, stone table, and stone stools. Ning Fuyi bent down to pick up a piece of hemp paper and examined it carefully, but found no writing on it.

All the other papers were the same - not even a drop of ink on them.

How strange. Did Chu Qingqiu only read heavenly scriptures¹? Ning Fuyi grumbled internally. Unable to find any clues, she angrily threw down the papers and turned to leave.

However, just as she stepped over the threshold, she heard a weak gasp from behind. Her steps paused, and she turned back.

Chu Qingqiu was still lying on her side in the same spot, her pure white dress hem wrapped around her like a late-blooming epiphyllum flower². The blood on her clothing left several glaring red spots.

Her disheveled hair clung to the side of her face, and with those peach blossom eyes tightly closed, she seemed to have lost some of her usual coldness.

Ning Fuyi hesitated for a moment, then walked back to Chu Qingqiu's side. She half-crouched down and once again grasped her arm to pull her into her embrace.

No matter how mature and strong a woman might appear outwardly, her body was ultimately soft. Nestled in her arms, she was as light as a feather, her cheek unconsciously resting against Ning Fuyi's shoulder, transmitting warmth through the fabric.

Nothing like that cold Divine Venerable who had lived for thousands of years.

While marveling at this in her heart, Ning Fuyi used her strength to position Chu Qingqiu flat on her back, placed her hands on her abdomen, and even helped adjust her dress hem. Only then did she stand up again, satisfied, and dusted off her hands.

For her, the peerless demon king of all four seas and eight desolate lands³, to show such kindness was truly rare.

After doing all this, she turned around and strode away.

Due to forcibly providing protection and using Gu techniques⁴ without permission, Ning Fuyi had expected to face many troubles upon returning to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. However, after hiding in Pearl Light Pavilion for two whole days, she hadn't received a single reprimand calling her to receive punishment.

The four great elders seemed to have forgotten about that day's events, or perhaps someone had interceded on her behalf, sparing her punishment out of consideration for her recent loss of her mother. For Ning Fuyi, not being punished was a good thing - there was no need to worry about the reasons.

So after two days, Ning Fuyi settled her mind and simply feigned illness to skip daily cultivation, instead secretly studying demonic cultivation methods.

However, no matter what path one cultivated, it required unity of mind and technique - internal cultivation of the heart's way, external training of muscles and bones, to achieve harmony. In her previous life, she had entered the demonic path through qi deviation⁵ caused by the tragic death of her close friends. In this life, she lacked such an opportunity, so practicing demonic arts was like being an outsider - she could only cultivate superficially and couldn't be considered a true demon.

Moreover, she had thought that due to her special extreme yin meridians⁶, she would find it easy to cultivate demonic arts. However, for some unknown reason, despite trying multiple times over the past two days, she had never been able to summon the familiar demonic power within her body.

This morning, with excellent sunlight, all the other disciples of Pearl Light Pavilion had gone outside for morning cultivation. Only then did Ning Fuyi get up and walk out from behind the screen, stretching toward the orange-yellow tinted wall.

She didn't want to have dealings with other disciples, so for several days she had been avoiding people when going in and out, stealing moments of peace.

She took a book she had been reading yesterday from beside her bed and walked from the bedroom to the main hall. The spacious area contained several square tables and rows of bookcases for disciples to study and review.

She searched for a moment, then stuffed the wrinkled ancient text back into its original position and sighed boredly.

This book recorded most types of contracts. She had originally wanted to look up explanations of marriage contracts, but found that the book mentioned only a few sparse words - nothing more than empty phrases like "once the contract is formed, destinies become one" - completely useless.

This thing looked like nothing more than a formal, useless contract no matter how she viewed it. Why had Chu Qingqiu formed such a contract with her?

Unable to understand, she could only think of finding another opportunity to test Chu Qingqiu.

"Yiyi." A familiar, gentle voice suddenly came from behind. Ning Fuyi turned with a smile and reached out her hand. A slender jade hand fell into her palm, while her other free hand held a heavy food box.

"I knew you hadn't gone to eat again," Liu Wenzhou⁷ chided. Today she wore a jade-green dress that would have been terribly vulgar on others, but on her it was like mountain bamboo - gentle and spiritual. "You haven't left your room for several days. You can't avoid cultivation for your entire life."

"Just a few more days," Ning Fuyi scratched the back of her head and sat down to open the food box.

"Although the sect master has just passed away, the Zhaoyao Grand Assembly⁸ is approaching - this is a great opportunity to distinguish yourself." Liu Wenzhou patiently persuaded her, but after speaking, she paused and added, "However, if you truly don't like cultivation, then this is fine too. When I achieve enlightenment, I'll protect you and absolutely won't let others bully you anymore."

A warmth she hadn't felt in a long time surged up, making Ning Fuyi's eyes a bit sore. She uncomfortably touched the bed.

After Liu Wenzhou's death in her previous life, for hundreds of years she could no longer bear to hear the word "protect." Every time she heard it, her heart felt like it was being cut by knives, and she would go on killing sprees.

"I'm just tired and want to rest. Don't worry, I will cultivate," Ning Fuyi said.

"You..."

"Wenzhou." The young woman placed her palm in Liu Wenzhou's hand, her dark eyes looking up at her. "You don't need to protect me. I will protect you."

Ning Fuyi knew she wasn't particularly likeable, so even as a child she never acted spoiled, but friends were the exception.

Hearing this, Liu Wenzhou's eyes curved into crescents as she smiled. She nodded emphatically and pushed the bowls and chopsticks on the table toward Ning Fuyi. "Alright, eat quickly."

Ning Fuyi suppressed the moisture in her eyes and lowered her head to eat.

Just as she swallowed the last grain of rice, a wooden puppet bird used for delivering messages flew in through the window. It opened its mouth and delivered a long string of vigorous scolding that made Ning Fuyi dizzy, and she had to cover her ears to feel better.

The message was from Elder Pingyao⁹, who used the most severe tone to thoroughly berate her, with earnest words that struck at her heart. She admonished her that cultivators should not wallow in grief, and with the Zhaoyao Grand Assembly approaching, she must practice diligently so as not to disgrace the former sect master.

Now Ning Fuyi couldn't escape even if she wanted to. She had to pull herself together and, along with the fellow disciples returning from morning cultivation, was dragged by Liu Wenzhou to Hanging Beam Garden¹⁰.

This place was where all disciples practiced their lessons, divided into four sections - east, west, south, and north - for use by disciples of the four corresponding levels: East Garden, West Garden, South Garden, and North Garden. East Garden had the highest cultivation levels, while North Garden was the opposite.

Ning Fuyi, Liu Wenzhou, and the others were all junior disciples, so they all belonged to North Garden.

Hanging Beam Garden was somewhat similar to mortal academies, with spider web-like covered walkways leading to various halls, only much larger and more magnificent. Precious jade stones were placed everywhere, emanating spiritual power and giving off colorful light.

It was still early, and the teaching elder hadn't arrived yet. Ning Fuyi yawned as she stepped over the threshold, only to be met immediately by a cold gleam. She hastily dodged sideways, barely avoiding having her neck sliced off by the cold light.

"Yiyi!" Liu Wenzhou nearby saw this and hurried over, angrily demanding, "Who did..."

"Oh my, if it isn't our young sect master?" A charming voice came from ahead, interrupting Liu Wenzhou's words. "We were just sparring. I didn't expect you to come today."

"After all, we weren't using our full strength. Even if an ordinary disciple took a blade to the face, they wouldn't be injured. But if it were you, I'm afraid it would have cost you your life. This is my fault for not considering your safety." Li Chaoan¹¹ said with a sweet smile.

Today she wore bright pink, her face like a peach blossom. When she smiled, two dimples appeared on her cheeks, making her look very innocent and adorable.

Li Chaoan had lost both parents at a young age, and Ning Changfeng's appearance had been like a lifeline of familial love to her, leading to her developing an obsessive possessiveness toward her mother figure.

Even before Ning Changfeng's death, Li Chaoan's attitude toward Ning Fuyi hadn't been good, but perhaps out of consideration for Ning Changfeng, she maintained a surface-level non-interference. It wasn't until after Ning Changfeng's death that the two began their open confrontation.

So if one were to rank the people Ning Fuyi hated most, Li Chaoan would definitely be among the top few.

"Nonsense! With so many disciples entering, you didn't spar with them, but you happened to spar just as we entered. Yiyi's body has just recovered, and you're nominally her sister - don't go too far," Liu Wenzhou said, her cheeks red with anger. Unfortunately, her naturally soft voice remained gentle even when arguing.

"So what? My adoptive mother never forbade sparring within the sect. She has no ability herself, yet expects others to yield to her - what kind of logic is that?" Li Chaoan was the most sharp-tongued, leaving the usually non-argumentative Liu Wenzhou speechless.

"Besides, I only acknowledge my adoptive mother. Someone so stupid doesn't deserve to be my adoptive mother's daughter, much less be my sister," Li Chaoan said with a light sneer.

Her words were truly excessive. Even Liu Wenzhou couldn't tolerate it, so she suddenly pushed Ning Fuyi aside and, with red-rimmed eyes, flipped her right hand. A flame emerged from her palm and surged toward Li Chaoan. Li Chaoan acted as if she completely disregarded her, not moving her hands at all. A white light appeared from the void and easily swallowed Liu Wenzhou's flame.

At the same time, the white light rushed toward Liu Wenzhou's cheek, clearly about to damage her appearance.

Footnotes:

¹ Heavenly scriptures (天书) - Sacred or divine texts, often incomprehensible to mortals

² Epiphyllum flower (昙花) - Also known as "Queen of the Night," a flower that blooms only once a year for a few hours at night; metaphor for something rare and fleeting

³ Four seas and eight desolate lands (四海八荒) - A poetic way of saying "the entire world" in Chinese literature

⁴ Gu techniques (蛊术) - Ancient Chinese mystical practices involving the use of venomous creatures or spiritual insects

⁵ Qi deviation (走火入魔) - A dangerous condition in cultivation where one's energy goes astray, often leading to madness or death

⁶ Extreme yin meridians (至阴之脉) - A rare constitution in cultivation novels, typically associated with darkness or demonic potential

⁷ Liu Wenzhou (柳文竹) - Ning Fuyi's closest friend; "Wenzhou" literally means "refined bamboo"

⁸ Zhaoyao Grand Assembly (招摇大会) - A major cultivation competition or gathering

⁹ Elder Pingyao (平遥长老) - One of the sect elders; "Pingyao" can mean "peaceful" or "tranquil"

¹⁰ Hanging Beam Garden (悬梁苑) - The training grounds; "hanging beam" likely refers to the architectural style

¹¹ Li Chaoan (李朝安) - Ning Fuyi's adoptive sister and rival; "Chaoan" can mean "facing peace" or "toward tranquility"